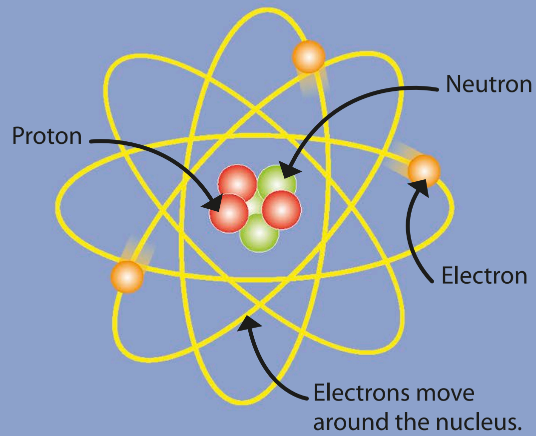
Giant loop
The Sun's superhot gases can form huge loops. If they break, these loops can send out high-energy matter into space. This matter can interrupt radio and television broadcasts on Earth, 150 million km (93 million miles) away.

Energy and atoms

Atoms are the tiny particles everything is made from. Inside every atom there are even smaller particles, which are held together by invisible forces that store energy.

Inside an atom
Atoms are made of three different types of particle – positively charged protons, negatively charged electrons, and neutrons, which have no charge. Protons and neutrons are found in the centre of the atom, in its nucleus.



Energy from atoms
The Sun is mostly made of hydrogen gas. It is so hot that its atoms lose their electrons, so just the nucleus remains. In the Sun, hydrogen nuclei join, or fuse, to make nuclei of helium atoms. This process, called nuclear fusion, releases lots of energy.